

## THE SOUTH AFRICAN STATISTICAL ASSOCIATION

### A SKETCH OF ITS ORIGINS AND GROWTH

In South Africa, as in every other country, interest in modern advances in statistical theory and technology grew rapidly after World War II. The earliest attempt to found a Statistical Association was made by Professor B. de Loor, Dr. (then Mr.) H.S. Sichel and myself in October, 1950. The records show that we consulted about twenty people in various parts of the country and decided that the time was not quite ripe.

Soon after, Professor de Loor visited America. One result of this visit was that when Professor Gertrude Cox, then head of the Statistical Institute at Raleigh, N.C. visited Africa in October 1953, Professor de Loor coaxed her to include South Africa in her itinerary and give some lectures. The lectures were duly held, the first in Pretoria and the second in Johannesburg. They were well attended and aroused considerable enthusiasm. I remember saying at the reception held after the second lecture, "Let us hold a meeting tomorrow to form our Association and here (turning to Professor de Loor) is our first President". This was duly done, and the Association began life with Professor de Loor as President, Professor Cox as Honorary Vice-President and about thirty members. Later, we had the further pleasure and privilege of appointing Professor A.C. Aitken of Edinburgh as an Honorary Vice-President.

Our small Association progressed steadily and to mark our fifth anniversary (greatly daring and completely impecunious) we held our first Conference in October 1958. As I wrote to Professor Cox at the time: "Eighteen papers were read. All of them were interesting and some were of a satisfactorily high standard. Considering that our total membership is sixty and that most of the papers were written by our younger members, we regard this as most satisfactory".

I claim that this optimism has been justified. Short Conferences are now held annually. On about half of these occasions we have been guests of large mining and industrial concerns, in order to promote the application of statistics in these fields and to learn more about the types of statistical problems encountered in practice.

Membership has reached one hundred and eighty, and the members' total output continually increases. Most members live in or near Pretoria and Johannesburg, but recently a branch was formed, with twenty five members, to serve Cape Town and Stellenbosch and their environs (almost a thousand miles away from our Headquarters).

Once again the decision to make a big step forward has been made and the Association has founded its own Journal. Its inception is due to the energy and enthusiasm of men younger than those who founded the Association, which is a good augury. Wish it well.

J.E. Kerrich.